ONE-PAGE SUMMARY · INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS OF PUBLIC DATA

Ownly: when customers pay and get nothing

Mahesh Kontham · Ownly teardown · 8 October 2026 · Full 43-page case study attached

1 in 3
negative customer reviews describe a paid order with no food (156 of 493)

1.05★
average rating when that happens

43%
of reasoned 4–5★ reviews praise price / no fees

The problem

In 1,000 Play Store reviews of the customer app (27 Sep–4 Oct 2026), the worst experience is not slow food or a weak menu. It is **paying and getting nothing**: the order is cancelled after payment, no captain comes, or it is marked "Delivered" without a handover. Refunds then get stuck ("refund stuck in initiated"), and 74 negative reviews use the words fraud or scam.

Why it matters to Ownly

Customers come for the price, and that is working: even 42 angry reviewers praise it. But with zero commission (reported) there is little margin to absorb a failed order, and with Rapido's app now sending new users (reported, Jul 2026), every failed first order wastes that distribution.

What the other two apps add

The restaurant and captain apps describe the same failures from the other side: order alerts that don't ring, so orders auto-cancel; captains sent before food is ready; captains reporting no orders for hours while customers wait for one. **Nothing in the order flow has to prove a handoff happened, and nothing refunds the customer automatically when one fails** (hypothesis).

What I would do

1. **Measure (2 weeks).** Severe-failure rate per 1,000 orders, and the 30-day repeat rate of customers whose order failed vs those whose order didn't. If failures are rare and customers still return, stop and move to another problem.
2. **Build Ownly Promise v1 (if the numbers justify it).** A 4-digit delivery code the captain must enter at handover, plus automatic refunds for three cases: cancelled after payment, no captain within 20 minutes, and "not received" on an unverified delivery. Every failure logged with a cause.
3. **Prove (4-week zone pilot).** Scale only if "not received" claims fall by at least 40% while captains keep accepting food orders and refund abuse stays low.

What I can't see from outside

This uses only public data: reviews, Semrush and press. I don't know Ownly's failure rate, refund times or repeat rates. That is exactly why step 1 is measurement. The case study labels every number as actual, estimate or assumption, and corrects four claims from my own earlier analysis.

> **PM DECISION · The ask**
> Let's discuss the findings and what to test next. Can we talk for 15 minutes?